Trump seeks to maintain GOP influence with red-state campaigning

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Scrutiny on financial institutions linked to illicit finance will improve US-Mexico cooperation
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Wealth tax’s failure in California would be a blow to national progressives

Trump seeks to maintain GOP influence with red-state campaigning. While President Trump has spent much of his campaign time so far in marginal races in which Republicans are playing defense, he’s also made a number of stops in deep-red territory where Democrats don’t have much of a chance this year: Tennessee, Alabama, Oklahoma, and Montana.

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On the face of it, this is a curious move: If Republicans believe their best chance of holding onto the House and Senate this year is to mobilize Trump’s base voters, who tend to have lower turnout at midterm elections, Trump should be spending all his time in contested seats.
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But Trump is fighting two battles at once: Not just to retain control of Congress, but also to retain his control over the party—and ensure that his influence is decisive in the 2028 presidential primaries. And in that latter battle, he faces a steep hill to climb, with his net approval rating among Republican voters having fallen well below where it was at the same point in his first term (see chart below).
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That’s the light in which Trump’s campaign efforts in deep-red states should be understood; these are in part attempts to revive his flagging appeal to Republican voters and to demonstrate that he’s still the power center in the party. Whether that strategy will pay off is less clear; Republican voters are willing to cut the president considerable slack, but the cumulative effect of high gas prices will continue to wear on his approval.

Scrutiny on financial institutions linked to illicit finance will improve US-Mexico cooperation. The US Treasury imposed more than $1.2 billion in penalties on Bank of America for anti-money laundering and sanctions violations, including failures to address risks linked to Chinese money-laundering networks and illicit finance along the US-Mexico border.

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Following the announcement, Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum's administration will likely continue its financial cooperation with the US to reduce the risk of further FinCEN actions against Mexican institutions. While US scrutiny will be calibrated to avoid excessive disruptions to the financial system, this oversight push will likely increase compliance costs for institutions on both sides.

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Banks will face pressure to strengthen their compliance and due diligence operations, preventing any perceived ties to organized crime, fentanyl trafficking networks, and Chinese trans-national crime organizations. The US has also maintained an interest in exposing financial links between cartels and certain political figures.

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Cross-border financial enforcement is now a key lever in the bilateral security relationship. Moving beyond kinetic law enforcement operations targeting criminal organizations, the US fine on Bank of America demonstrates Washington's deepening cooperation with Mexico to root out money flows supporting cartel networks. The fine also provides President Sheinbaum political top cover to engage more aggressively without the appearance of unilateral strong-arming from President Trump.

Wealth tax's failure in California would be a blow to national progressives. The most important state referendum on the ballot in November—California's proposal for a one-time 5% wealth tax on the state's billionaires—doesn't look likely to pass, with recent polls showing the "Yes" side polling just under the necessary 50%.

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Caveats are needed here, since polling of California ballot initiatives is difficult at best. But such initiatives tend not to gain in support over time, with undecided voters typically breaking to the status quo option close to election day. Prediction markets see it as having only 25% chances of passage, down from the mid-30s in September.

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If the initiative fails, it would raise question about the political viability of what has become a de rigueur component of progressives' platforms across the country—including Abdul El-Sayed's in Michigan—and what would likely be a major element of any progressive campaign for the 2028 presidential nomination.

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Progressives probably wouldn't respond to a California defeat by backing off their proposals. What's more likely is that more 2028 contenders would take the approach favored by California Governor Gavin Newsom, who has opposed wealth-tax proposals but has called instead for a "true minimum tax on billionaires," along with reforms to inheritance rules and other "loopholes."

Quote of the Day

"Their leaders are gone. That's one of the problems—I might've gone too far. I don't know who the hell to deal with." - Trump speaking about the Iran war at a rally in Arizona yesterday; the US and Iran have been unyielding in their negotiating positions over the past few weeks, and Iran's stepped-up attacks on

shipping have made the Trump administration consider launching new strikes.

On the Radar

12-18 October: IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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